

MATTHEW COETZEE

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EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame

Ph.D., Sociology with Minor in Screen Cultures 2023 – Expected May 2026
Dissertation: *Rupture and Repair: Community Responses to State Failure and Racial Violence in Post-Apartheid South Africa*
Advisors: Ann Mische & Terry McDonnell

University of Notre Dame

M.A., Sociology 2021 – 2023
Thesis: *Disruptive Events, Adhocracies, and Symbolic Boundaries in Post-Apartheid South Africa: Democratic Resilience on the Fly in July 2021*
Advisors: Ann Mische & Lyn Spillman

SOAS University of London

M.S., Public Policy and Management 2019 – 2021

Yale University

B.A., Double Major in Sociology and African Studies (with Distinctions) 2014 – 2018
GPA: 3.81
Sociology Thesis: *Social Networks and Structural Diversity at College: African Student Networks, Identity and Integration*
Advisor: Grace Kao
African Studies Thesis: *Robben Island: Perspectives on Dark Tourism and the Search for Authenticity*
Advisor: Philip Smith

RESEARCH AND TEACHING INTERESTS

Cultural Sociology; Theory; Sociology of Morality; Qualitative Methods; Social Movements and Collective Behavior; Social Solidarity; Digital Sociology; Global and Comparative Sociology.

HONORS & AWARDS

Harry Frank Guggenheim Emerging Scholars Award, <i>Guggenheim Foundation</i> , \$25,000	2025
Becker Award, Best Graduate Research Paper in Sociology, <i>University of Notre Dame</i>	2024
R.F. Thompson Award for Outstanding Research in African Studies, <i>Yale University</i>	2018
Rhodes Scholarship Finalist – Southern Africa, <i>Rhodes Trust</i>	2018

PUBLICATIONS

Peer Reviewed Publications

- 1) **Coetzee, Matthew**. 2025. "Recurating Robben Island: Cultural Objects, Digital Memory, and the Entropic Afterlives of National Heritage." *American Journal of Cultural Sociology* 13(1):1–33

Book Manuscript

- 2) Smith, Christian, **Matthew Coetzee**, and Bridget Ritz. *Re-enchanted America*. Forthcoming. Book manuscript under contract with Oxford University Press

Under Review

- 3) Summers-Effler, Erika and **Matthew Coetzee**. "Targeting and Orienting: A Framework for Analyzing Social Change Efforts." *American Sociological Review*
- 4) **Coetzee, Matthew** and Junhui Cai. "Ethical Adhocracies: Collective Memory and Moral Organization of Crisis Response." *Journal of Business Ethics* Special Issue on Business, Ethics, and Collective Memory

Book Chapters

- 5) **Coetzee, Matthew**, Erika Summers-Effler, Hyunjin Kwak, and Justin Van Ness. "Mapping Social Change Efforts: A Dynamic and Integrative Four-Quadrant Framework." Invited chapter **accepted for inclusion** in *Culture and Social Movements*, edited by Guya Accornero and James M. Jasper

Working Papers

Nearing Completion

- 6) **Coetzee, Matthew**. "Contingent Memory Activation: Collective Memory, Crisis Response, and the Dynamics of Social Action." In preparation for *American Sociological Review*
- 7) **Coetzee, Matthew**. "When Meaning Acts: A Critical Realist Cultural Sociology from the Global South" In preparation for *Sociological Theory* (Special Issue on Global Theory)
- 8) Summers-Effler, Erika, **Matthew Coetzee**, Stephanie Israel, and Simone Polillo. "Nuance, Transposability, and Creativity: How Perception Produces the Potential for Social Change." In preparation for *American Journal of Sociology*

Works in Progress

- 9) **Coetzee, Matthew**. "Perceptual Aperture Dynamics: Cognition and Cultural Responses to Disruption and Stability." Manuscript in preparation for *Sociological Theory*
- 10) **Coetzee, Matthew**. "Structural Integration at Elite Universities: Symbolic Boundary Making of Pan-African Identity" Manuscript in preparation for *American Journal of Cultural Sociology*
- 11) **Coetzee, Matthew**. "Protest Performance and Strategic Misalignment: Solidarity, Audience, and the Limits of Mobilization in Hong Kong" Manuscript in preparation for *Mobilization*

PRESENTATIONS

American Sociological Association Annual Meeting, Panel Discussion, Chicago, USA 2025

"Rupture, Repair, and the Civil Sphere: Moral Solidarity and Dynamics of Perception in Post-Apartheid South Africa"

CBSM: On the Many Impacts of Social Movements, Northwestern University, Chicago, USA 2025

<i>"Contingent Memory Activation and Civil Repair: Collective Memory and Crisis Response"</i>		
Civil Sphere Theory Working Group , University of Vienna, Vienna, Austria		2025
<i>"Eventful Sociology and Civil Sphere Theory: Resisting Unrest in Post-Apartheid South Africa"</i>		
Social Science History Association Annual Meeting , Culture Network, Chicago, USA		2025
<i>"Rupture, Repair, and the Civil Sphere: Moral Solidarity and Dynamics of Perception"</i>		
Democracy, Autocracy and Protest: Social Movements in Times of Crisis , San Diego, USA		2025
<i>"Contingent Memory Activation and Civil Repair: Collective Memory and Crisis Response"</i>		
American Sociological Association Annual Meeting, Panel Discussion , Montréal, Canada		2024
<i>"Adhocracies, Collective Memory, and Cohesion Amidst Civil Unrest in Post-Apartheid South Africa"</i>		
University of Notre Dame, Rome Global Gateway , Rome, Italy		2023
<i>"Has Christianity Become Obsolete? Shifts in Deep Culture and Young Adult Indifference"</i>		
Civil Sphere Theory Working Group, University of Trento , Trento, Italy		2021
<i>"Founding Moments and Civil Repair,"</i> Lyn Spillman with Matthew Coetzee and Isaac Kimmel		

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

Wilsey Distinguished Graduate Fellowship, Institute for Ethics and the Common Good, \$44,000	2025
Pre-Doctoral Fellow, Center for Cultural Sociology, Yale University	2025 – Present
Kellogg Institute Fellow, \$6,000 annually	2021 – Present
Institute of Arts and Letters: Technology and the Common Good Research Grant, \$4,300	2024
Kellogg Institute Graduate Research Grant, \$3,750	2022
Sorin Fellow, de Nicola Center for Ethics and Culture	2021 – Present
Yale-China Fellowship, \$15,000	2018 – 2020

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant , University of Notre Dame	2021 – Present
Foundations of Sociological Theory (SOC 34090)	
Kinship on the Margins: Encountering Poverty and the Catholic Social Tradition (PS 30600)	
Confronting Social Issues: International (THEO 33938)	
Research on American Cultural Change and Secularization I & II (SOC 40966 & 44966)	
U.S. Change & Secularization III (SOC 43966)	
Marriage and the Family (SOC 20342)	

ADDITIONAL RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Project Manager	2022 – 2024
Professor Christian Smith, University of Notre Dame	
<i>Why Religion Went Obsolete: The Demise of Traditional Faith in America</i> , Oxford University Press	
• Managed a team of six undergraduate researchers conducting and coding 200+ in-depth interviews • Led data coding and thematic analysis of interviewees' religious life histories • Compiled appendices and selected quotations for the published book	

- Mentees progressed into careers in academia, counseling, education, consulting, and university administration

Graduate Research Assistant

2021 – 2022

Professor Lyn Spillman, University of Notre Dame

- Assisted with research for “Founding Moments and Civil Repair” invited talk on the 1619 Project & America 250 Projects at the Civil Sphere Working Group

Pre-Doctoral Research Assistant, Yale-China Fellowship

2019 – 2021

Professor Andrew Junker, Chinese University of Hong Kong

- Conducted research on the Anti-Extradition Bill (“Antielab”) protests, focusing on protest dramaturgy and social movement dynamics in Hong Kong

PROFESSIONAL WORK EXPERIENCE

NTK Academic Group, Hong Kong, HK

2020 – 2021

Instructor, English and Humanities Department

- Taught English and Humanities at Hong Kong’s leading academic group for international curricula
- Developed and published academic course materials, including *Writing for Academic Achievement*, *Literary Analysis and Commentary*, and *Standardized Test Preparation*

Yale-China Association, Changsha, China

2018 – 2020

Yale-China Fellow

- Continued a 120+ year tradition of cross-cultural engagement through education and healthcare initiatives in mainland China
- Established new Yale-China education initiatives in Western Hunan in partnership with local NGOs
- Taught English at Yali High School, a Yale-China partner institution and one of the oldest U.S.–China educational collaborations
- Co-directed a bilingual student production of *Into the Woods*
- Mentored students in U.S. college admissions, two of whom matriculated to Stanford and NYU

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

American Sociological Association Sections: Altruism, Morality, and Social Solidarity, Theory, Culture, Social Movements and Collective Behavior

Social Science History Association

Civil Sphere Theory Working Group

Center for Cultural Sociology, Yale University

SERVICE AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

University of Notre Dame, Notre Dame, Indiana, USA

<i>Graduate Student Council</i> , Academic Affairs	2025 – Present
<i>Ethnography Workshop Coordinator</i>	2024 – Present
<i>Founding Member</i> , Friends at Midnight, Catholic LGBTQ+ Faith Group	2024
<i>Graduate Student Volunteer</i> , Open Search Committee	2024
<i>Volunteer Coordinator</i> , St. Augustine's Church Soup Kitchen	2023 – Present

Yale University, New Haven, Connecticut, USA

Associate Fellow, *Yale Young African Scholars Program*, Rwanda & Zimbabwe 2017 – 2018

- Facilitated college-prep seminars on social enterprise, religion, and politics for high-achieving, low-income students from over 30 African countries
- Provided year-long mentorship on SAT prep, application strategy, and U.S. college essays

Yale Chaplaincy Fellow, *Yale Chaplain's Office* 2016 – 2017

- Organized four campus-wide events exploring religious pluralism, purpose, and interfaith engagement
- Participated in a service-learning trip to Washington, D.C., volunteering with the World Food Bank and engaging with diverse local faith communities

Political Chair (2016) & Outreach Chair (2015), *Yale African Students' Association* 2015 – 2016

- Served on the executive board, advocating for the social and political representation of African students
- Lead planner for *Africa Week*, managing guest travel, programming, and funding logistics
- Launched “African Connections,” a cross-diasporic dialogue series among African, Caribbean, and African-American students on race, identity, and belonging

Inclusion Council Member, *Yale International Students' Organization* 2016

- Co-authored a policy report on international student well-being, focusing on financial aid
- Resulted in stronger mental health support and more transparent aid processes

Hillcrest AIDS Centre Trust, Durban, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa

Volunteer Research Assistant 2016

- Designed an educational impact survey for 8,000 rural youth across KwaZulu-Natal
- Analyzed outcomes used to secure international donor funding for youth empowerment and HIV prevention programming

SKILLS

Research Methods: Qualitative Interviewing, Thematic Coding, Case Study Analysis, Comparative-Historical Methods, Visual Content Analysis, Survey Design, Social Network Analysis (R), Grounded Theory

Digital Tools & Programming: R, Stata, Gephi, ArcGIS, Atlas.ti, NVivo

Languages: English (Native), Afrikaans (Working Proficiency), Mandarin (Limited Working Proficiency), Zulu (Conversational Proficiency)

REFERENCES

Ann Mische

University of Notre Dame

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Studies

Email: Ann.E.Mische.2@nd.edu

Christian Smith

University of Notre Dame

William R. Kenan, Jr. Professor of Sociology

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Erika Summers-Effler

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Philip Smith

Yale University

Professor of Sociology

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Lyn Spillman

University of Notre Dame

Emeritus Professor of Sociology

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Terry McDonnell

University of Notre Dame

Henkels Family College Professor and
Sociology Department Chair

Email: tmcdonn2@nd.edu